

Chapter 57-2: 失落 (Loss)

"Father, this is Yiyi, and this lady is..."

Before Liu Wenzhu could finish speaking, the Liu family head, who had been sitting steadily in his chair, sprang up. Ning Fuyi didn't even see how he maneuvered around the tables and chairs before he had already rushed forward and bowed in greeting.

Apart from a face full of stubble that couldn't be completely shaved, his other features bore some resemblance to Liu Wenzhu, only more rugged. Upon closer inspection, he could be considered decent-looking, just with more wrinkles around his eyes.

"I have long admired the great name of Divine Venerable Chu Ling. Seeing you today, you are indeed as the rumors say—peerlessly beautiful with extraordinary bearing!" He bowed while backing away, extending both hands: "Please sit, Divine Venerable, please sit."

He didn't spare even half a glance for Ning Fuyi.

"No need for such ceremony." Chu Qingqiu shook her head, but she couldn't withstand such an enthusiastic Liu family head and was almost forcibly invited to take the seat of honor.

Liu Wenzhu gently nudged Ning Fuyi's waist and whispered in her ear: "Don't mind it. My father is just like this. Come, let's sit over here."

She pulled Ning Fuyi to sit at the side. Ning Fuyi watched Liu family head Liu Wenhai's attitude, which could only be described as fawning, and couldn't help but shake her head.

She had rarely heard Liu Wenzhu mention her father, but remembering how he had saved her life in her previous existence, she had thought this person should be an upright man. She hadn't expected that seeing him now, he would be so...

Opportunistic.

Upon seeing Chu Qingqiu, he couldn't even be bothered to acknowledge the guest he had brought along.

"I've always instructed my Wenzhu to seek more guidance from the sect's elders. Her mother passed away early, and this child is my only flesh and blood, Liu Wenhai. She absolutely cannot be ordinary like common disciples." Liu Wenhai poured wine for Chu Qingqiu while speaking.

"It's just a pity she's a daughter, and her talent isn't exceptional either. If she wants to inherit the position of sect leader legitimately, it's extremely difficult. More than a dozen branch families are watching like tigers, and there are several decent male descendants in the main family as well—wolves in front and tigers behind, it's truly difficult. But now with a sect leader like the Divine Venerable supporting her, I hope the Divine Venerable will give her more guidance in the future!" Liu Wenhai said with a smile.

Liu Wenzhu must have heard these words often at home. Her pretty head hung low as she drank the tea before her.

Ning Fuyi was feeling somewhat indignant when she heard Chu Qingqiu speak lightly: "Family Head Liu, this venerable one is also a daughter."

Liu Wenhai's smile froze on his face for a moment, then he patted his mouth and laughed awkwardly: "The Divine Venerable is a once-in-a-generation talent. How could my little daughter compare to the Divine Venerable?"

Seeing that Chu Qingqiu wasn't speaking anymore, he touched his nose and smiled as he turned to the handsome young man he had brought: "Wenzhu, this is the one father often mentions to you—the young sect leader of Feihua Sect¹, one of the six sects."

"Father, your child came down the mountain on important business and has no mind for other matters." Liu Wenzhu suddenly stood up, her water-like eyes not even lifting: "Your child will go attend to business first. Please continue."

With that, she pulled Ning Fuyi and turned to leave the private room. Ning Fuyi hadn't even taken a sip of tea before she was directly lifted up by her, carried out without her feet touching the ground.

"Wenzhu!" Liu Wenhai quickly stood up. Chu Qingqiu beside him also rose and took her leave.

In the end, only Liu Wenhai and the Feihua Sect young leader remained in the room. The two men looked at each other awkwardly. Liu Wenhai sighed heavily and gestured: "Come, come, let's eat."

Liu Wenzhu hadn't gone far either, but casually entered another private room. She whispered to Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu: "Divine Venerable, Yiyi, I'm sorry you had to see that. My father, he..."

"No matter." Chu Qingqiu spoke, sweeping her sleeves as she took a seat again. "A father hoping his daughter will succeed is understandable to this venerable one. So what exactly happened in Qi Kingdom?"

Only then did Liu Wenzhu remember the important matter. She sat down properly and was about to speak when Ning Fuyi suddenly reminded: "Don't we need to find somewhere without people?"

"It's fine." Liu Wenzhu covered her lips and smiled. "This wine house is the Liu family's property. Everyone outside is our own people."

Ning Fuyi made an "ah" sound and looked enviously toward the door, thinking how other people's parents would leave some family business for their children, while only Ning Changfeng had lived a life of carefree poverty with empty sleeves, leaving nothing but a broken courtyard.

Even Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate had fallen into someone else's hands. She couldn't help but sigh.

"Qi Kingdom was originally a peaceful place that hadn't seen war for a hundred years. It had a female emperor who maintained harmony between ruler and ministers and governed the country well. But these past two months, somehow this female emperor's temperament has drastically changed. Not only does she indulge in pleasure and refuse to hold court, she's also become obsessed with sensual pleasures and sends people to gather attractive young men and women from various places to the palace every other day."

"Moreover, if no new men and women are sent in for extended periods, she becomes furious and beats anyone she sees with boards. I heard that among the servants in the palace who can meet the female emperor, not one has an intact backside." Liu Wenzhu said with a red face.

"I originally thought that as a cultivator, I could just use an invisibility technique to enter the palace and see what had happened to her. Unfortunately, that palace is sealed with layers of barriers. Not only can't you get in, but even if you sneak in invisibly, your immortal power will rapidly drain away and you'll be exposed."

"If I hadn't run fast, I probably would have lost my life by now." Liu Wenzhu said with lingering fear.

Ning Fuyi was very surprised. To be able to drain someone's immortal power required extremely powerful demonic force. She quickly asked: "Did you sense any demonic energy?"

"That's what's strange about it. I circled the palace walls for several days without sensing even a trace of demonic energy. Besides those barriers, I didn't detect anyone else's immortal power either." Liu Wenzhu shook her head. "Perhaps my cultivation is too low to detect it."

Unable to figure it out, Ning Fuyi looked toward Chu Qingqiu and found that even she showed a puzzled expression.

"We probably can only find out what happened by infiltrating and seeing that female emperor in person." Chu Qingqiu spoke.

"But the palace is heavily guarded. Ordinary people simply can't get in, and immortal power becomes ineffective." Liu Wenzhu clutched the table edge in distress.

Ning Fuyi and Chu Qingqiu exchanged glances, then both lowered their heads, understanding each other's meaning.

"We can infiltrate." Ning Fuyi curved her phoenix eyes and tapped her index finger on the table.

Liu Wenzhu's almond eyes slowly widened. Just as she was about to speak, Chu Qingqiu suddenly looked up toward the door: "Must you wait for this venerable one to impose sect punishment before you'll come out?"

Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu looked toward the door in confusion and saw a corner of light purple skirt fabric flutter out, followed by someone timidly entering their view, head lowered and not daring to speak.

"Qiu Yi?" Liu Wenzhu's eyes widened.

"When did you arrive?" Chu Qingqiu's expressionless questioning was extremely intimidating. Qiu Yi didn't even dare raise her head, her fingertips twisted almost into knots in front of her.

"This afternoon..."

"Now you've learned to disobey your master's orders, act on your own, and report after the fact?"

"Master, please forgive this disciple!" Qiu Yi's knees went weak and she knelt down, her tall figure now carefully hunched over, as if afraid of making Chu Qingqiu angry. "This disciple was just angry that Master wouldn't let this disciple go out to train. In a moment of confusion, I secretly ran out. When I heard there was trouble here, I came."

"Please punish this disciple!" She prostrated on the ground, knocking her forehead against the floor with a loud thud. Liu Wenzhu's body trembled hearing it, and she couldn't help but tug at Ning Fuyi.

In her previous life, Chu Qingqiu had indeed let her go out to train—hadn't she died training under her own hands? Ning Fuyi looked away.

Just as Chu Qingqiu was about to speak, Ning Fuyi suddenly called out "Divine Venerable."

She looked up to see Chu Qingqiu's red lips pressed tightly together, clearly suppressing anger, but she didn't scold further.

"Get up. We'll discuss this matter after returning to the sect." After speaking, she stood up and walked past the kneeling Qiu Yi with her hands behind her back. Her cool robe brushed across Qiu Yi's forehead, and the previously red and swollen forehead became smooth and unblemished again.

Qiu Yi touched her head in amazement, then beamed with joy, scrambling up and following closely behind. Liu Wenzhu also breathed a sigh of relief, whispering: "That scared me to death. I thought the Divine Venerable was going to punish her in front of us. Liu Wenzhu is soft-hearted and can't bear to see people suffer punishment."

"Is Chu Qingqiu so frightening in your eyes? Always hitting people?" Ning Fuyi couldn't help but say.

Liu Wenzhu looked somewhat surprised at these words. She pinched Ning Fuyi's face: "Yiyi, didn't you always say the Divine Venerable was cold-hearted? How is it that you're changing your tune now?"

Only then did Ning Fuyi realize the change in her own mindset. She quickly laughed it off with a few "ha-ha"s and pulled Liu Wenzhu away.

Half an hour later, their group held the imperial proclamation calling for young men and women and walked into a resplendent clothing shop.

This clothing shop also belonged to the Liu family, so it had been cleared of customers and was spacious and quiet.

Chu Qingqiu had originally wanted to directly transform into the appearance of a mortal, but Liu Wenzhu and Qiu Yi both wanted to experience how mortal women dressed and applied makeup. So she also kept a straight face and let the shop girls hold rouge and makeup brushes, applying cosmetics to her face.

Ning Fuyi was the first to finish. She wandered around the room bored, and only when the other three had finished did she turn to look.

The first person she saw was Chu Qingqiu—for no other reason than that she was simply too outstanding. That face was already like rosy clouds against snow even without powder or rouge. Now adorned with cosmetics, coldness was mixed with brilliance, transforming into the most passionate divine flower under the morning glow.

Ning Fuyi's heart pounded rapidly. She quickly looked away, pretending not to have seen Chu Qingqiu.

"How is it, Yiyi? Does it look good?" Liu Wenzhu walked over with a smile, asking expectantly.

She was indeed elegant and ethereal. Ning Fuyi smiled with curved eyes: "Beautiful."

Seeing the two chatting animatedly, Chu Qingqiu stood in place with her hands at her sides, hiding the flash of loss in her eyes as she turned toward Qiu Yi, who was admiring herself in the bronze mirror.

After hesitating, she finally spoke quietly: "Disciple, does your master look... unsightly like this?"

Footnotes:

1. 飞花教 (**Feihua Sect**) - Literally "Flying Flower Sect," one of the six major sects mentioned in the story.